



Tips & Tricks



How to use *diff* and *patch*

You have created a program *prog.c* and also copied to *prog.c.old*. You post *prog.c* to users. Next, you make changes to *prog.c* and want to release a patch. Here is how you can do it:

```
diff -c prog.c.old prog.c > prog.patch
```

Users can now get the latest updates by running:

```
patch < prog.patch
```

—Remin Raphael, remin13@gmail.com



Five useful shell-prompt tips

1) We always define the alias for a shortcut. But, sometimes, we don't need that and want the original effect of the command. For example:

```
alias ls='ls -ls'
```

Now to restrict the alias effect and see the native command, we can execute it in any of the following three ways:

```
$ command ls
$ !ls
$ !ls
```

- 2) If you want to check whether an alias is assigned to a particular command, you can use the *type* command with an alias name as follows:

```
$ type ls
```

You can also use the *unalias* command to revert back to the original *ls* command:

```
$ unalias ls
```

This will display the alias name, if the alias is assigned.

- 3) To open an application from the command line in GNOME, we can use the *gnome-open* command. For example:

```
$ gnome-open jash.xls
```

This will open the file with the application associated with it.

- 4) Here is a useful way to use the append operator. To append text at the end of a file, we simply use the *>>* character. But if we want to append text at the beginning of the file, run the following command:

```
$ echo "hi jash" | cat - file.txt > /tmp/out && mv /tmp/out file.txt
```

By using this command, the "hi jash" line will be added at the beginning of the file.

- 5) If you want to find all files with the extension *.txt* and *.jpg*, then use the following command:

```
$ find . -type f -iname "*.txt" -or -iname "*.jpg"
```

...where the *-type f* parameter is used to find files and *-or* is used for the 'or' operation.

If you want to exclude hidden files in this 'find', then use the *!* (not) operator:

```
$ find . -type f -iname "*.txt" ! -iname ".*"
```

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Identify zombies

Do you need to identify the process ID of a zombie process, and also know which program the process belongs to? Execute the following command to get the list of zombie processes: